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A FIELD GUIDE FROM PERSEVERANT DIGITAL · FOR RECRUITING AND STAFFING

The Cost-per-Appointment Blueprint for Meta Ads

Work out what you can afford to pay for a booked appointment, choose an offer worth raising a hand for, and set up Meta lead campaigns judged on appointments, not cheap leads.

THE SHORT ANSWER · 65 WORDS

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Facebook and Instagram ads can produce real appointments for a high-value service business when three things line up. You know the most you can pay per booked appointment, you lead with one offer worth raising a hand for, and someone calls every lead within minutes. Judge the campaign on booked and held appointments, because the cheapest leads are often the least likely to show up.

Many owners who say Facebook ads “don’t work” are judging them on the wrong number. A cheap lead goes to voicemail, so the channel looks like junk. An expensive lead gets the campaign switched off before it books anyone.

This guide gives you a better scoreboard: the most you can pay for a booked appointment. Everything else is built to hit it.

Step 1: What can you afford to pay for a booked appointment?

Your ceiling comes from your own numbers, not an industry average. Use the last 12 months. Where you don’t track a number, use an honest guess and mark it.

Line	Your number
Average first-year value of a new client	$
× Gross margin (%) = value of a new client	$
× Close rate from a held appointment (%) = value of a held appointment	$
× Show rate (%) = value of a booked appointment	$
× Share you'll spend on acquisition (%)	
= Maximum cost per booked appointment	**$**

Use first-year value, not lifetime value. It keeps you safe while you learn what Meta leads actually do.

A worked example. Example numbers, not benchmarks.

- $8,000 first-year value × 50% margin = $4,000 per new client
- $4,000 × 25% close rate = $1,000 per held appointment
- $1,000 × 70% show rate = $700 per booked appointment
- $700 × 30% spend share = **$210 maximum cost per booked appointment**

Now work backward. If 40% of leads book, this business can pay up to $84 per lead. If only 10% book, it needs leads under $21. A $30 lead that books half the time is cheaper than a $12 lead that almost never does.

For first-year value, use what a typical new account produces in 12 months, not your largest account.

- [ ] Fill in the worksheet and circle every guess
- [ ] Post your maximum cost per booked appointment where your team can see it

What this looks like for recruiting and staffing firms

Your buyer is an employer, not a job seeker. Owners and hiring managers scroll Facebook and Instagram on their own time, so your ad has to catch a business problem in a personal moment: a role open too long, a team stretched thin, a busy season coming.

Growth is modest. Staffing Industry Analysts expects the US staffing market to grow 2.4% in 2026, to $183.1 billion (SIA, September 6, 2026). In a slow market, new accounts go to firms that follow up well, not the ones that spend the most.

Keep employer campaigns and job ads apart, because only job ads fall under Meta's employment rules (see Step 4). Qualify on company size, roles and hiring timeline. A hiring needs call is the most direct offer. Automate the admin, but keep the first conversation human.

Step 2: Which offer is worth raising a hand for?

Pick one offer per campaign. It should match how ready the prospect is and never promise a result.

Offer	Fits	Keep it clean
Hiring needs call	Any employer	Say what the call covers
Salary guide for one role family	Employers planning hires	Cite the salary data source
Workforce planning session	Larger or seasonal employers	No promised time-to-fill
"Cost of an open role" worksheet	Owners with long-open roles	Example numbers labeled

- [ ] Would a serious prospect find this useful even if they never hire us?
- [ ] Can we deliver it well at the volume a campaign could send?
- [ ] Is the wording free of promised outcomes or savings figures?

Step 3: Lead form or landing page?

Start with Meta's Instant Form set to Higher intent, add one or two multiple-choice qualifying questions, and move to a landing page only if lead quality stays low. Higher intent adds a review screen before submitting. It costs some volume and screens out some accidental taps.

Option	Use it when	Watch out for
Instant Form, More volume	Your team can call everyone fast	Accidental submissions, wrong numbers
Instant Form, Higher intent	You want fewer, more deliberate leads	Slightly higher cost per lead
Either form plus qualifying questions	You need to route by location, timeline or service	More than two questions hurts completion
Landing page	The offer needs explaining, or you want booking on the spot	Needs fast load, clean tracking, short form

Ask only what the first call needs.

Step 4: What are the rules for your category?

Check your category before you build. This is a factual summary, not legal advice.

- **Employment.** Job ads fall under Meta's employment category: age fixed at 18–65+, gender and ZIP targeting restricted, no lookalikes. Ads selling your service to employers generally don't, but check each campaign (Meta Marketing API documentation).
- **Texts and calls (everyone).** Prior express written consent is still required for autodialed or prerecorded marketing texts and calls, and since April 11, 2025 opt-outs by any reasonable means must be honored within 10 business days (Kelley Drye; Burr & Forman).
- **Testimonials (everyone).** The FTC's August 2024 rule bans fake, bought and undisclosed insider reviews (Morgan Lewis, August 26, 2024).

Step 5: How do you test creative in 14 days?

Run three hooks across two formats, keep the offer, audience and form fixed, and judge on booked appointments. The hook, the first line or first two seconds, is usually your biggest lever.

	Short video, talking to camera	Single image with text
Hook 1: the problem in the prospect's words		
Hook 2: what happens at the appointment		
Hook 3: a common mistake or myth		

- [ ] Days 1–7: Launch all six and leave them alone. Pause early only if an ad spends well past your target with zero leads.
- [ ] Days 8–14: Compare booked appointments by ad. Pause clear losers, keep the top one or two.
- [ ] Day 15: Write down what you learned and change one thing for the next round.

Cost per booked appointment decides. Cost per lead and click-through rate only help you diagnose.

Step 6: What happens after someone fills out the form?

Call every lead within minutes and track each one to a result. This decides more than any ad does. In a Harvard Business Review data set of 1.25 million leads, firms that made contact within an hour were nearly seven times as likely to qualify the lead as firms that waited longer (HBR, March 2011).

Let automation send the confirmation text. A person should make the call.

Date	Name	Ad or hook	Minutes to call	Reached?	Booked?	Held?	Won?	Value

Each week, divide spend by booked appointments and compare it to your Step 1 ceiling.

- [ ] Name who owns new leads at every hour you advertise
- [ ] Add an "ad or hook" field to every lead record

Where do most owners get stuck?

> **Sending CRM outcomes back to Meta correctly.** Meta's Conversions API can learn from "booked" and "held" events, but only if lead IDs match, timing is right and nothing sensitive goes along. Get it wrong and Meta learns the wrong lesson.

> **Making enough creative to beat fatigue.** Winning ads wear out. Most small teams run out of time for new hooks before the campaign runs out of steam.

> **Reaching the person who decides.** Meta brings office managers, job seekers and owners in the same week. Getting the hiring decision-maker on a call takes routing most firms build by trial and error.

If you've filled in the worksheet and want a second set of eyes on the numbers, book a 25-minute exploration call with the short form at the end of this guide.

Sources

- Meta for Developers, "Special Ad Category," accessed October 15, 2026. link
- Kelley Drye, "Eleventh Circuit Vacates TCPA One-to-One Consent Rule," January 24, 2025. link
- Burr & Forman, "The FCC Delays Effective Date of TCPA Revoke-All Rule Until January 31, 2027," accessed October 15, 2026. link
- Morgan Lewis, "FTC Issues Final Rule on Consumer Reviews and Testimonials," August 26, 2024. link
- Harvard Business Review, "The Short Life of Online Sales Leads," Oldroyd, McElheran and Elkington, March 2011. link
- Staffing Industry Analysts, "US Staffing Industry Forecast: September 2026 Update," September 6, 2026. link

Want a second set of eyes on what you found?

Book a free 25-minute exploration call. We will look at your answers with you, name the first fixes in order, and tell you honestly if we are not the right fit.

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